



Rising star: Feeling the pressure to become The Next Great American Player, Coco Gauff sometimes struggles but always competes hard. GETTY IMAGES



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In the post-Serena Williams era, several female players have jockeyed to fill that massive void: Naomi Osaka, Ashleigh Barty, Iga Swiatek, and, currently, Aryna Sabalenka. Swiatek has captured the most Grand Slam titles — five. With a ferocious topspin forehand, blazing foot speed, and relentless intensity, she's dominated one tournament and one surface more than her rivals, winning four Roland Garros titles and six others on clay.

A year ago, before Swiatek trounced surprise finalist Jasmine Paolini 6-2, 6-1 in the final, *NBC* analyst John McEnroe said, "She's fast becoming the Rafa Nadal on this surface," referencing the 14-time Roland Garros champion. After the final, all-time great Chris Evert, who racked up seven French titles, predicted, "She is the best clay court player, bar none. I have no doubt she'll break my record."

No tennis expert could

have foreseen Swiatek's sudden fall from the pinnacle of the sport at age 23 — especially her unexpected decline on clay. It started with her stunning semifinal loss to Zheng Qinwen at the Paris Olympics. Swiatek hasn't even reached a final in her last 14 tournaments across all surfaces.

This shocking reversal of fortunes leaves the French Open wide open, with no clear favourite. Here are my five top contenders, the dark horses, and the predicted champion.

No. 3 Coco Gauff

Since she upset Sabalenka in the 2023 US Open final as a 19-year-old phenom, Gauff has been hot and cold. Feeling the pressure to become The Next Great American Player, she sometimes struggles in matches but always competes hard.

Named in *TIME* magazine's 2024 Women of the Year list — which honours "extraordinary leaders working toward a more equal world" — Gauff had an ordinary year by her high standards. The fleet Floridian failed to make a Grand Slam final or medal at the Paris Olympics, but salvaged the season by capturing the 2024 WTA Finals with impressive wins over No. 1 Sabalenka, No. 2 Swiatek, No. 6 Pegula, No. 7 Zheng, and No. 8 Barbora Krejčíková.

Gauff's coach, Matt Daly, has tweaked her forehand and serve grips to solidify these strokes so she can confidently attack with fewer errors. "Her forehand looked as good as it's ever looked," praised former No. 1 Jim Courier when Gauff thrashed Swiatek 6-1, 6-1 in the Madrid Open semis — the Pole's worst loss on clay in six years. Gauff has now won three straight matches in their rivalry after losing 10 of their first 11.

Gauff can easily make the semis or final — but beating Sabalenka is a bridge too far.

No. 2 Iga Swiatek

What's wrong with Swiatek (**left**)? A coaching change from Tomasz Wiktorowski to the highly regarded Wim Fissette hasn't diversified her inflexible, one-dimensional game. Her most alarming match stat is second serve points won. In 2024,